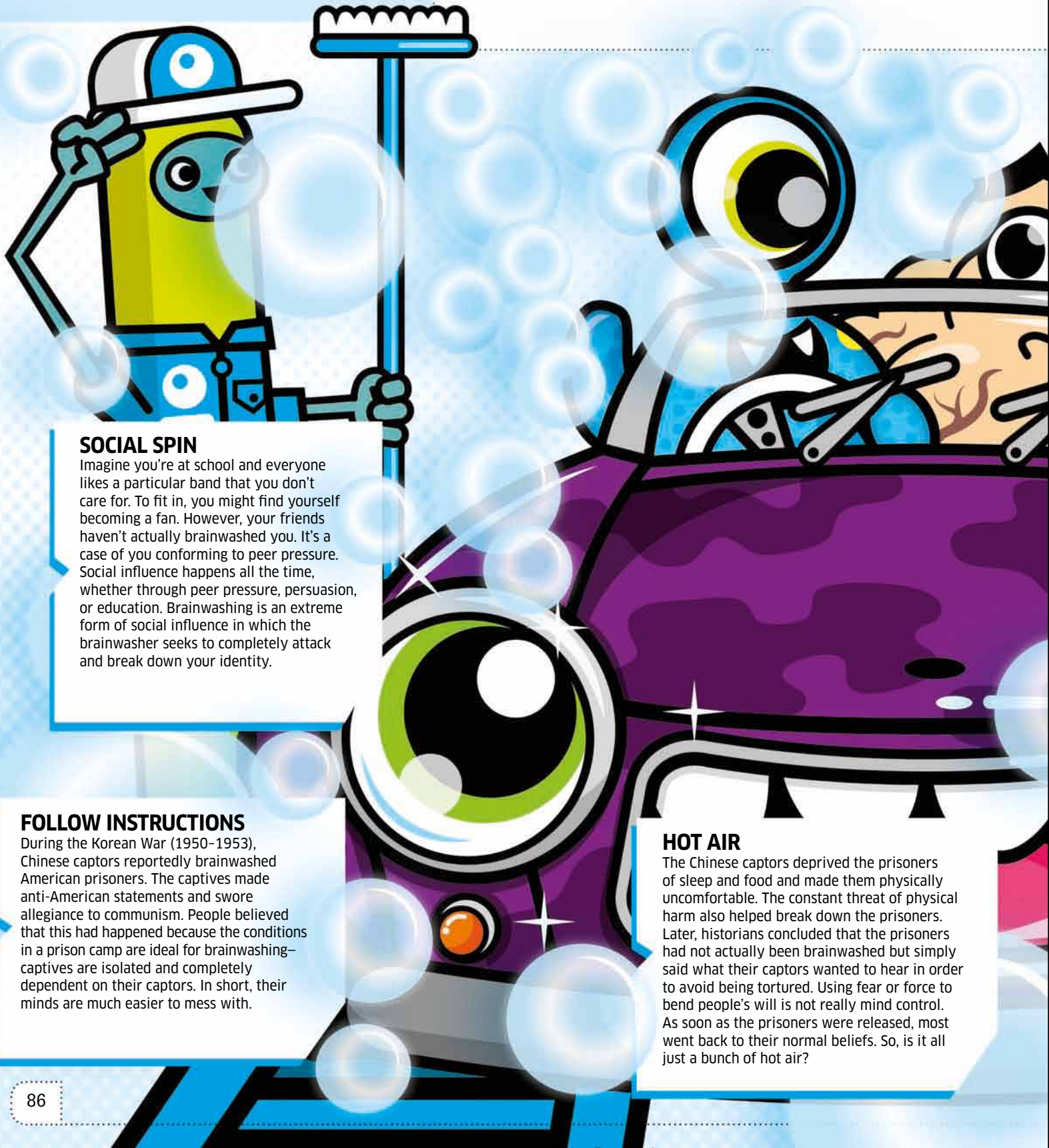


CAN I BE BRAINWASHED?

You can shampoo your hair or take a bubble bath, but can you be brainwashed? Brainwashing (or mind control) is when someone takes control of another person's thoughts and actions against their will. It may be used to force the victim to abandon a political, social, or religious belief and accept the brainwasher's point of view. Or, do you think this is all hogwash? Put your brain into gear and read on . . .



SOCIAL SPIN

Imagine you're at school and everyone likes a particular band that you don't care for. To fit in, you might find yourself becoming a fan. However, your friends haven't actually brainwashed you. It's a case of you conforming to peer pressure. Social influence happens all the time, whether through peer pressure, persuasion, or education. Brainwashing is an extreme form of social influence in which the brainwasher seeks to completely attack and break down your identity.

FOLLOW INSTRUCTIONS

During the Korean War (1950–1953), Chinese captors reportedly brainwashed American prisoners. The captives made anti-American statements and swore allegiance to communism. People believed that this had happened because the conditions in a prison camp are ideal for brainwashing—captives are isolated and completely dependent on their captors. In short, their minds are much easier to mess with.

HOT AIR

The Chinese captors deprived the prisoners of sleep and food and made them physically uncomfortable. The constant threat of physical harm also helped break down the prisoners. Later, historians concluded that the prisoners had not actually been brainwashed but simply said what their captors wanted to hear in order to avoid being tortured. Using fear or force to bend people's will is not really mind control. As soon as the prisoners were released, most went back to their normal beliefs. So, is it all just a bunch of hot air?